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Akamai Technologies, Inc. | North America

Feedback After the Recent Stock Reaction — Growth to Accelerate But ROI Taking on Greater Focus

Growth acceleration is increasingly validated, but returns, concentration and funding now central to the debate. We see better economics than the sell-off implies, while FY27 execution and financing remain key. Reiterate OW.

Key Takeaways

- Investor debate has shifted from whether growth accelerates to whether the ROI, EPS and funding profile support a higher multiple
- We see better economics than the sell-off implies, with our analysis pointing to ~11% cash IRR and ~30%+ steady-state operating margins
- Customer concentration likely caps near-term multiple expansion, though capacity/revenue-per-MW disclosures support confidence in execution
- ORCL/CRWV analogies miss AKAM's stronger starting liquidity and differentiated software/network stack, though incremental funding remains a risk
- FY27 guidance and execution against the contracted revenue ramp are the key next proof points, with early expansion supporting product resonance. Reiterate OW.

What Has Been the Feedback Following the Recent CIS Announcement?

Following the initial ~25% move higher in shares after Akamai announced the expanded $11.6 billion customer commitment, the stock has given back much of those gains as the debate has shifted from whether growth can accelerate to whether investors can underwrite the ROI profile, earnings profile and valuation of that growth. We continue to view the deal as a significant validation of the CIS opportunity: Akamai now has ~$14.4 billion of signed CIS commitments, with the latest contract expected to begin contributing revenue in 2H27, generate $150–300 million in FY27, and ramp to an approximately $1.7 billion annualized run-rate by the end of 2028. However, our investor conversations have increasingly centered on four concerns: 1) whether returns on the invested capital are attractive enough, particularly given lower FY27 EPS; 2) rising customer concentration; 3) growing comparisons to complex AI infrastructure stories such as Oracle and CoreWeave; and 4) the potential need for Akamai to raise additional capital to fund the $5.5 billion in capex required to support the contract. We address each below.

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Akamai Technologies, Inc. (AKAM.O, AKAM US)

Software | United States of America

Stock Rating	**Overweight**
Industry View	**Attractive**
Price target	**$165.00**
Shr price, close (Sep 28, 2026)	$108.99
Mkt cap, curr (mm)	$16,167
52-Week Range	$165.45-70.82

Fiscal Year Ending	12/25	12/26e	12/27e	12/28e
EPS ($)**	7.12	6.72	6.89	7.53
Prior EPS ($)**	-	-	-	-
P/E	20.8	26.3	28.4	25.8
EPS ($)§	7.04	6.67	6.71	7.93
Div yld (%)	-	-	-	-

Unless otherwise noted, all metrics are based on Morgan Stanley ModelWare framework
** = Based on consensus methodology
§ = Consensus data is provided by Refinitiv Estimates
e = Morgan Stanley Research estimates

QUARTERLY EPS ($)

Quarter	2025	2026e Prior	2026e Current	2027e Prior	2027e Current
Q1	1.70	-	1.61a	-	1.56
Q2	1.73	-	1.59a	-	1.64
Q3	1.86	-	1.68	-	1.67
Q4	1.84	-	1.91	-	2.02

e = Morgan Stanley Research estimates, a = Actual Company reported data

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1) Do the Returns Justify the Size of the Investment?

Near-Term IRR Math Screens More Challenging Than the Long-Term Economics. This has been the most consistent pushback following the announcement. Akamai expects to spend ~$5.5 billion to support the latest $11.6 billion contract, including ~ $1.7 billion in 4Q26, ~$3.1 billion in FY27 and another ~$700 million in FY28, while revenue does not begin until 2H27 and only reaches steady state exiting 2028. Against that cadence, investors running a seven-year return framework have concluded that the contract looks less compelling absent either an extension beyond the initial term or the potential additional $9 billion expansion. Compounding the concern, the investment comes ahead of the revenue and depreciation begins as assets enter service, which places material pressure on FY27 EPS despite a substantial acceleration in revenue growth.

We Think Focusing on Accounting EPS Understates the Cash Economics. We disagree with the conclusion that the contract is unattractive from a cash-return perspective. Using our assumptions around the disclosed capex schedule, revenue ramp and steady-state profitability, we calculate an approximately 11% IRR after adding back D&A. The contract also does not require Akamai to refresh the hardware during its seven-year life, and management noted that it operates servers beyond seven years today. There is therefore meaningful upside to the return profile if the assets remain productive after the initial contract or the relationship renews. We believe renewal is a reasonable possibility given both the duration of the relationship and the strategic nature of the infrastructure, though the ultimate durability of the customer's business remains an important risk.

Exhibit 1: We estimate ~11% IRR on the $11.6bn expansion deal

	2026	2027	2028	2029	2030	2031	2032	2033	2034
Revenue		225	1370	1657	1657	1657	1657	1657	1719
EBIT		**$0**	**$411**	**$497**	**$497**	**$497**	**$497**	**$497**	**$516**
EBIT Margin		*0%*	*30%*	*30%*	*30%*	*30%*	*30%*	*30%*	*30%*
Taxes		**$0**	**$78**	**$94**	**$94**	**$94**	**$94**	**$94**	**$98**
Tax Rate		*19%*	*19%*	*19%*	*19%*	*19%*	*19%*	*19%*	*19%*
NOPAT		**$0**	**$333**	**$403**	**$403**	**$403**	**$403**	**$403**	**$418**
Capex	($1,700)	($3,100)	($700)						
Depreciation		$107	$650	$786	$786	$786	$786	$786	$815
FCF	**($1,700.0)**	**($2,993.3)**	**$282.5**	**$1,188.4**	**$1,188.4**	**$1,188.4**	**$1,188.4**	**$1,188.4**	**$1,233.0**
IRR	11%								

Source: Company Disclosures, Morgan Stanley Research

Steady-State Operating Margins Also Look Attractive. Our prior analysis on the broader contracted CIS portfolio pointed to steady-state operating margins of ~30% or better (see Growth Set to Shift to an Even Higher Gear With Major $12 Billion Contract Win, Reiterate OW). Akamai has disclosed that the ~$14.4 billion of signed CIS commitments should generate approximately $2.2 billion in annual recurring revenue when fully ramped using roughly 95–105 MW of power, or about $22 million of annual revenue per MW. Using approximately $1.0 billion of annualized capex/depreciation expense, ~$350 million of colo expense and ~$150 million of operating expense, our framework implies operating margins of roughly 30%+ – supporting our view that the deal should ultimately be margin-accretive despite the near-term EPS dilution.

2) Does Customer Concentration Put a Ceiling on the Multiple?

Investor concern has increasingly focused on the degree to which recent bookings are concentrated in the Q1 customer, with ~90% of recent CIS bookings as tied to this customer. The issue is not whether the contract is committed — the $11.6 billion deal is take-or-pay once Akamai delivers the capacity — but rather how much of the company's future growth and infrastructure investment is now dependent on the financial health and long-term compute requirements of one AI-native customer. Management expects the contract to reach approximately $1.7 billion of annual revenue once fully ramped and remain at that level thereafter under the take-or-pay structure. In our view, that concentration likely limits how aggressively investors are willing to capitalize the higher growth rate before Akamai proves execution.

Capacity Disclosures Are More Constructive Than the Concentration Debate Suggests. The portfolio economics are not based on speculative capacity. Across the ~$14.4 billion of contracted CIS business, management expects 95–105 MW to support ~$2.2 billion of fully ramped annual revenue. Capacity is distributed across numerous colocation providers and locations rather than concentrated in one large datacenter, and management noted that some capacity has already been secured. That matters because it reduces the binary execution risk associated with a single large campus and preserves the ability to redeploy infrastructure if customer requirements change. Management also indicated that the hardware represents highly demanded capacity that could potentially be reused or resold should the customer relationship change.

Ultimately, we think the concentration discount should decline as Akamai demonstrates that it can stand up the required capacity, recognize the contracted revenue and win additional customers. Management noted that signing larger deals has already increased inbound interest from customers that previously did not view Akamai as capable of operating at this scale.

3) Analogies to More Complex AI Infrastructure Stories in Software

A recurring investor concern is whether Akamai is becoming an Oracle-like story — significant AI infrastructure investment funded with more debt and increasing exposure to a concentrated group of AI-native customers — or a CoreWeave-like story in which skeptical investors ultimately view the product as undifferentiated bare-metal compute paired with long-term agreements.

On the Oracle comparison, the commonality is clear: a substantial increase in AI infrastructure investment ahead of contracted revenue can cause earnings and free cash flow to diverge meaningfully from reported growth. However, we view Akamai as entering this investment cycle from a better capital position and with less of its longer-term financial framework already constrained by infrastructure commitments. Akamai reported ~$4.6 billion of cash entering the transaction and has access to a $1 billion revolver. We nevertheless think incremental financing is likely, which keeps the comparison relevant from a stock-debate perspective even if the balance-sheet starting point differs.

On the CoreWeave comparison, we think the market risks understating the software and network value embedded in Akamai's offering. The $11.6 billion contract uses Akamai's existing architecture and software stack, requiring limited incremental R&D or sales-and-marketing investment, while management sees opportunities over time to attach agent sandboxing, AI security, model-as-a-service and other Akamai services. Akamai also brings the global network fabric, security stack and *distributed infrastructure that already supports all three hyperscalers as CIS customers*. We therefore do not view this simply as a bare-metal capacity resale model.

We are also more constructive on the long-term agreements themselves. If compute scarcity ultimately eases, the ability to lock in multi-year committed revenue should become more valuable rather than less — particularly as signed commitments convert into backlog/RPO and improve forward revenue visibility.

4) How Does the Funding Requirement Complicate the Story?

It appears increasingly likely to us that Akamai ultimately raises incremental capital, most likely debt. We are positive on the company's ability to access the public capital markets, but more cautious on what that transition means for the stock. Akamai historically screened as a highly cash-generative infrastructure/software business. Moving toward a model where growth is increasingly funded with debt-financed capex changes the earnings, FCF and balance-sheet characteristics investors are underwriting — and potentially changes the natural shareholder base. There is also an unusual near-term dynamic whereby additional large CIS wins could simultaneously improve the long-term revenue outlook and result in another round of near-term EPS/FCF estimate reductions as investment moves ahead of revenue. That flywheel is strategically positive but can remain challenging for the stock until investors gain greater confidence in the returns and funding framework.

5) What Do We Do With the Stock From Here?

Akamai Has Become a Show-Me Story. The latest deal meaningfully strengthens the case that the growth inflection is real. The question for the stock is increasingly whether the company can translate bookings into revenue and cash returns without allowing the required investment, customer concentration and funding needs to overwhelm the re-rating from faster growth. The first important proof point will be FY27 guidance. If guidance provides enough confidence in the expected revenue ramp, we think the debate around simply "showing the revenue" becomes less important and investor focus can shift toward the medium-term economics.

Clearest product proof point is the customer behavior itself. The relationship that began with a much smaller commitment earlier this year expanded rapidly into an $11.6 billion agreement, suggesting the offering resonated meaningfully through the initial deployment and evaluation process. Management also indicated that the opportunity set has expanded as other large customers see Akamai executing at greater scale. We see that as an important offset to the current concentration debate.

Our estimates remain under review.

Valuation Methodology and Risks

Akamai Technologies, Inc. (AKAM.O)

~24x Base Case CY27 EPS of $6.89. Given divergence between cloud infrastructure and security valuations and the lack of clean core comps, this is at a discount to company's closest valuation peer. EPS grows at a ~6% FY26-FY28 CAGR.

Risks to Upside

- Security growth improves to the double digits
- Compute business accelerates to 20%+
- Traction with Akamai Inference Cloud improves growth and expands the multiple

Risks to Downside

- Delivery business sees steeper declines
- Security slows further
- Capex spending accelerates while compute growth doesn't improve
- Edge computing opportunity fails to materialize

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ServiceNow Inc, ServiceTitan Inc, Shopify Inc, Snowflake Inc., Tenable Holdings Inc, Toast, Inc., Twilio Inc, UiPath Inc, Varonis Systems, Inc., Wix.Com Ltd, Workday Inc, Zeta Global Holdings Corp, Zoom Communications, Zscaler Inc.

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(as of August 31, 2026)

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	Coverage Universe		Investment Banking Clients (IBC)			Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC)	
Stock Rating Category	Count	% of Total	Count	% of Total IBC	% of Rating Category	Count	% of Total Other MISC
Overweight/Buy	1555	42%	450	48%	29%	767	44%
Equal-weight/Hold	1577	43%	395	42%	25%	770	44%
Not-Rated/Hold	3	0%	1	0%	33%	1	0%
Underweight/Sell	559	15%	93	10%	17%	216	12%
Total	3,694		939			1754	

Data include common stock and ADRs currently assigned ratings. Investment Banking Clients are companies from whom Morgan Stanley received investment banking compensation in the last 12 months. Due to rounding off of decimals, the percentages provided in the "% of total" column may not add up to exactly 100 percent.

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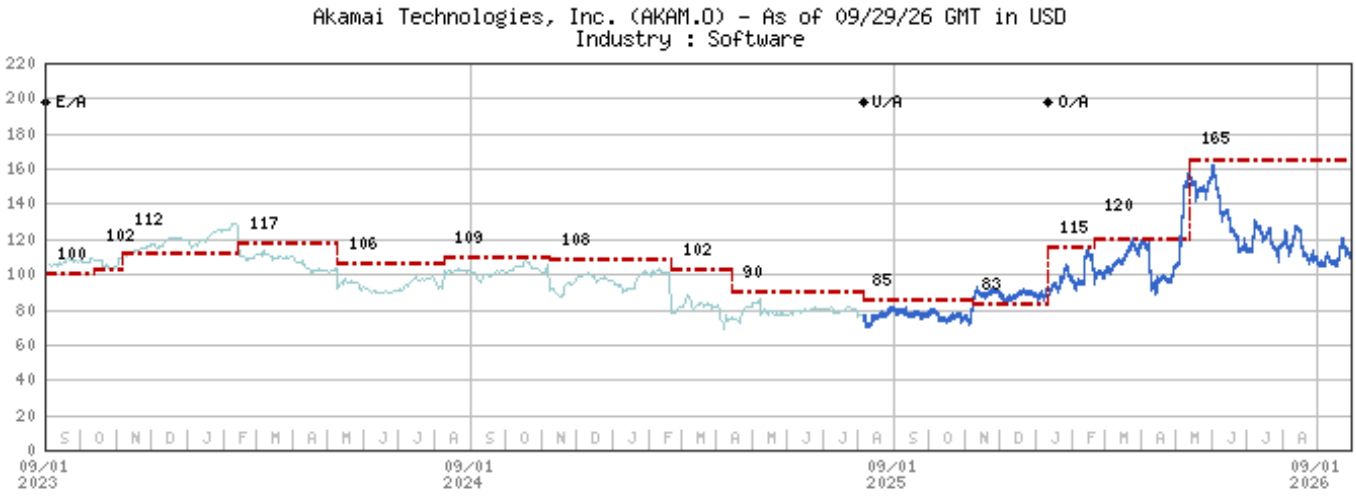
Attractive (A): The analyst expects the performance of his or her industry coverage universe over the next 12-18 months to be attractive vs. the relevant broad market benchmark, as indicated below.

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Stock Price, Price Target and Rating History (See Rating Definitions)



Stock Rating History: 9/1/21 : E/A; 8/5/25 : U/A; 1/12/26 : O/A

Price Target History: 5/5/21 : 119; 11/3/21 : 130; 5/4/22 : 118; 7/11/22 : 110; 8/10/22 : 102; 10/20/22 : 98; 11/9/22 : 92; 5/10/23 : 94; 8/9/23 : 100; 10/13/23 : 102; 11/7/23 : 112; 2/14/24 : 117; 5/10/24 : 106; 8/9/24 : 109; 11/8/24 : 108; 2/21/25 : 102; 4/15/25 : 90; 8/5/25 : 85; 11/7/25 : 83; 1/12/26 : 115; 2/20/26 : 120; 5/14/26 : 165

Source: Morgan Stanley Research Date Format : MM/DD/YY Price Target No Price Target Assigned (NA)
Stock Price (Not Covered by Current Analyst) Stock Price (Covered by Current Analyst)
Stock and Industry Ratings (abbreviations below) appear as ◆ Stock Rating/Industry View
Stock Ratings: Overweight (O) Equal-weight (E) Underweight (U) Not-Rated (NR) No Rating Available (NA)
Industry View: Attractive (A) In-line (I) Cautious (C) No Rating (NR)

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COMPANY (TICKER)	RATING (AS OF)	PRICE* (09/28/2026)
Adam Wood		
Adobe Inc. (ADBE.O)	U (07/21/2026)	$231.01
Atlassian Corporation PLC (TEAM.O)	O (01/13/2020)	$178.54
Intuit (INTU.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$269.40
Microsoft (MSFT.O)	O (07/21/2026)	$509.22
Salesforce, Inc. (CRM.N)	E (07/21/2026)	$227.27
Samsara Inc (IOT.N)	E (03/23/2023)	$37.93
ServiceNow Inc (NOW.N)	O (09/24/2025)	$131.45
Shopify Inc (SHOP.O)	O (04/19/2024)	$144.01
Workday Inc (WDAY.O)	U (07/21/2026)	$188.60
Chris Quintero		
BILL Holdings Inc (BILL.N)	E (06/10/2025)	$41.60
Blackline Inc (BL.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$26.56
Box Inc (BOX.N)	E (05/21/2024)	$31.34
CCC Intelligent Solutions Holdings Inc (CCC.O)	O (11/13/2024)	$6.62
Descartes Systems Group Inc (DSGX.O)	O (01/15/2026)	$78.85
DocuSign Inc (DOCU.O)	E (01/16/2024)	$66.98
Manhattan Associates Inc. (MANH.O)	E (10/21/2025)	$201.88
Navan Inc (NAVN.O)	O (11/24/2025)	$19.98
ServiceTitan Inc (TTAN.O)	O (01/20/2026)	$59.92
SPS Commerce Inc (SPSC.O)	U (07/21/2026)	$81.01
Vertex Inc. (VERX.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$11.06
Via Transportation Inc (VIA.N)	O (01/20/2026)	$29.10
Elizabeth Porter, CFA		
Amplitude Inc. (AMPL.O)	O (01/15/2026)	$13.30

Asana Inc (ASAN.N)	U (05/20/2025)	$8.64
Autodesk (ADSK.O)	O (08/23/2024)	$207.19
Figma Inc (FIG.N)	E (08/25/2025)	$20.25
Five9 Inc (FIVN.O)	E (10/10/2022)	$34.66
Freshworks Inc (FRSH.O)	E (10/18/2021)	$12.53
GoDaddy Inc (GDDY.N)	E (07/19/2021)	$93.71
HubSpot, Inc. (HUBS.N)	O (03/21/2023)	$202.84
Klaviyo, Inc (KVYO.N)	O (04/29/2026)	$15.40
Liveramp Holdings Inc (RAMP.N)	E (01/13/2025)	$37.63
monday.com Ltd (MNDY.O)	O (08/12/2025)	$79.05
NICE Ltd. (NICE.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$109.09
Octave Intelligence Plc (OCTV.O)	E (09/17/2026)	$18.58
RingCentral Inc (RNG.N)	E (08/08/2023)	$76.13
Sprinklr Inc (CXM.N)	E (07/19/2021)	$4.98
Sprout Social Inc (SPT.O)	E (11/17/2020)	$9.47
Toast, Inc. (TOST.N)	O (12/16/2021)	$30.38
Twilio Inc (TWLO.N)	O (02/24/2025)	$286.98
Wix.Com Ltd (WIX.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$69.60
Zeta Global Holdings Corp (ZETA.N)	E (08/01/2024)	$28.99
Zoom Communications (ZM.O)	E (10/11/2022)	$87.30
ZoomInfo Technologies Inc (GTM.O)	E (02/01/2024)	$3.59
Meryl R Thomas, CFA		
Lightspeed Commerce Inc. (LSPD.N)	E (02/18/2021)	$9.69
Meta A Marshall		
Check Point Software Technologies Ltd. (CHKP.O)	E (10/16/2023)	$129.27
CrowdStrike Holdings Inc (CRWD.O)	O (03/10/2026)	$259.25
Fortinet Inc. (FTNT.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$176.33
Gen Digital Inc. (GEN.O)	E (06/07/2024)	$20.85
Netskope, Inc. (NTSK.O)	O (10/13/2025)	$17.85
Okta, Inc. (OKTA.O)	O (12/02/2024)	$202.18
Palo Alto Networks Inc (PANW.O)	O (10/10/2017)	$392.09
Qualys Inc (QLYS.O)	U (02/09/2021)	$173.83
Rapid7 Inc (RPD.O)	U (07/21/2026)	$11.80
SailPoint Inc (SAIL.O)	O (09/02/2025)	$20.57
SentinelOne, Inc. (S.N)	E (12/02/2024)	$22.74
Tenable Holdings Inc (TENB.O)	E (12/02/2024)	$34.47
Varonis Systems, Inc. (VRNS.O)	E (01/26/2026)	$47.93
Zscaler Inc (ZS.O)	E (04/22/2026)	$199.39
Ryan Lountzis		
CoreWeave (CRWV.O)	E (04/22/2025)	$85.07
Nebius Group NV (NBIS.O)	E (01/15/2026)	$231.88
Sanjit K Singh		
Akamai Technologies, Inc. (AKAM.O)	O (01/12/2026)	$108.99
Appian Corp (APPN.O)	E (04/30/2026)	$35.02
C3.ai (AI.N)	U (01/04/2021)	$10.41
Cloudflare Inc (NET.N)	O (12/02/2024)	$353.99
Datadog, Inc. (DDOG.O)	O (01/12/2026)	$268.70
DigitalOcean Holdings Inc (DOCN.N)	O (01/16/2025)	$136.29
Dynatrace Inc (DT.N)	O (08/25/2026)	$57.84
Elastic NV (ESTC.N)	E (07/21/2026)	$87.94
GitLab Inc (GTLB.O)	E (01/12/2026)	$46.21
JFrog Ltd. (FROG.O)	E (07/21/2026)	$88.81
MongoDB Inc (MDB.O)	O (04/12/2023)	$334.68
Oracle Corporation (ORCL.N)	E (01/15/2019)	$132.60

PagerDuty, Inc. (PD.N)	U (07/21/2026)	$14.48
Palantir Technologies Inc. (PLTR.O)	E (02/04/2025)	$187.48
Snowflake Inc. (SNOW.N)	O (06/24/2025)	$328.12
UiPath Inc (PATH.N)	E (09/07/2022)	$12.19

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